

TRADITIONAL CLOTHING

“Clothing carries identity through form, fabric and memory.”

Clothing is one of the most visible forms of cultural memory. A garment can reveal climate, occupation, social setting, generation, occasion and personal taste. For the Orakzai, clothing exists within the wider clothing traditions of the Pashtun world and the mountain environment of northwestern Pakistan. Some garments are widely associated with Pashtun identity. Others belong to broader regional traditions. And some details may be local to particular communities or families. The challenge is therefore not to invent a single ‘Orakzai costume.’ It is to understand how clothing has been worn, adapted and remembered.



“The layered process of clothing as an expression of identity.”

KEY PRINCIPLE: LAYERED IDENTITY

Clothing identity is layered. A garment can be Pashtun, regional, local, family-specific, and individual at the same time. This complexity means that shared culture does not mean

identical culture. While certain items are widely worn across the Pashtun belt, their specific application in Orakzai reflects local conditions and tribal memory.



“Hierarchical model of clothing identity layers.”

MEN'S TRADITIONAL DRESS

Traditional attire for men in Orakzai and the wider KP region is centered on practicality and modesty. The khet partug, consisting of a knee-length tunic and loose trousers, is a historically documented garment in the tribal areas. The pakol and various turban styles (lungee) serve as key identity markers, while the Peshawari chappal remains the regional standard for footwear.

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MEN'S CLOTHING ECOSYSTEM

SHALWAR KAMEEZ
(PASHTUN WIDE)

KHET PARTUG
(REGIONAL)

PAKOL / TURBAN
(PASHTUN WIDE)

SHAWL / CHADAR
(PASHTUN WIDE)

PESHAWARI CHAPPAL
(REGIONAL)

“Documented men's garments and their evidence levels.”

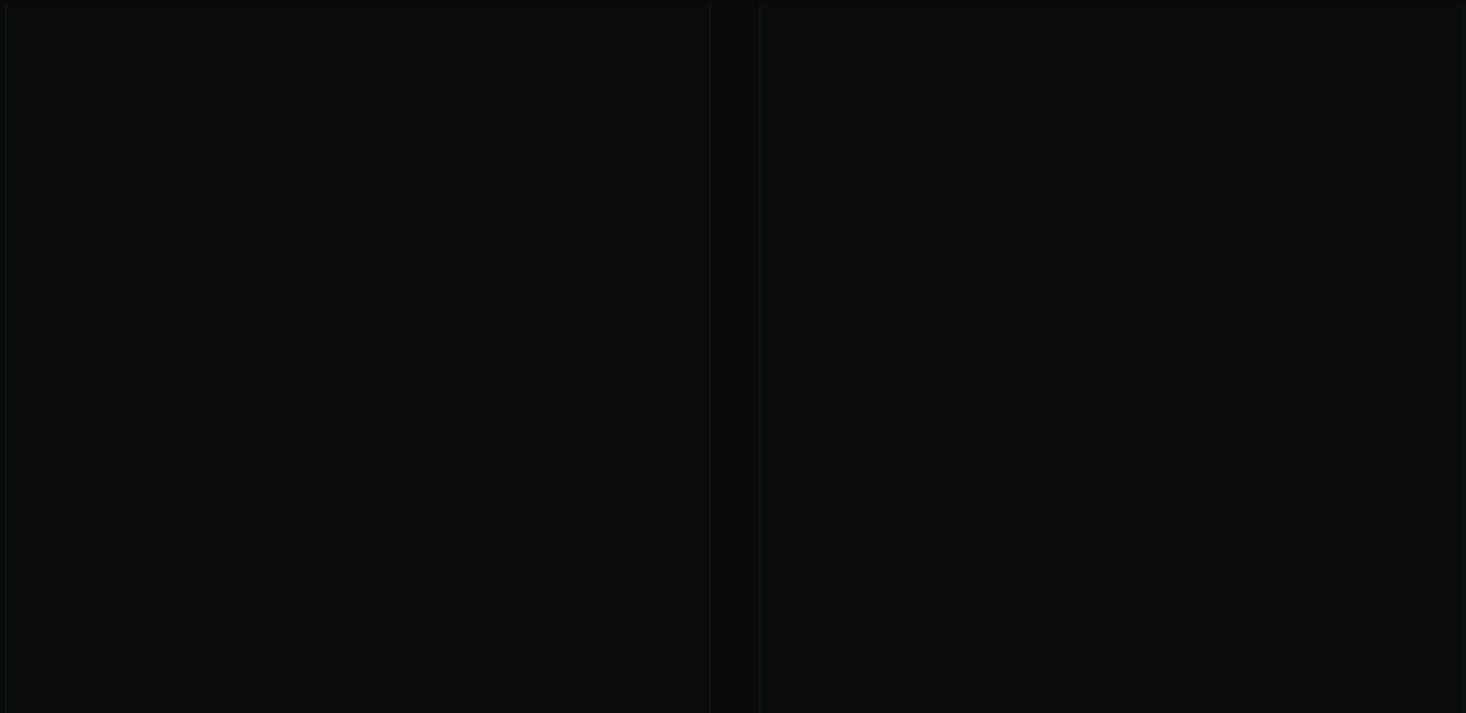
HEADWEAR & IDENTITY

HEADWEAR

REGION

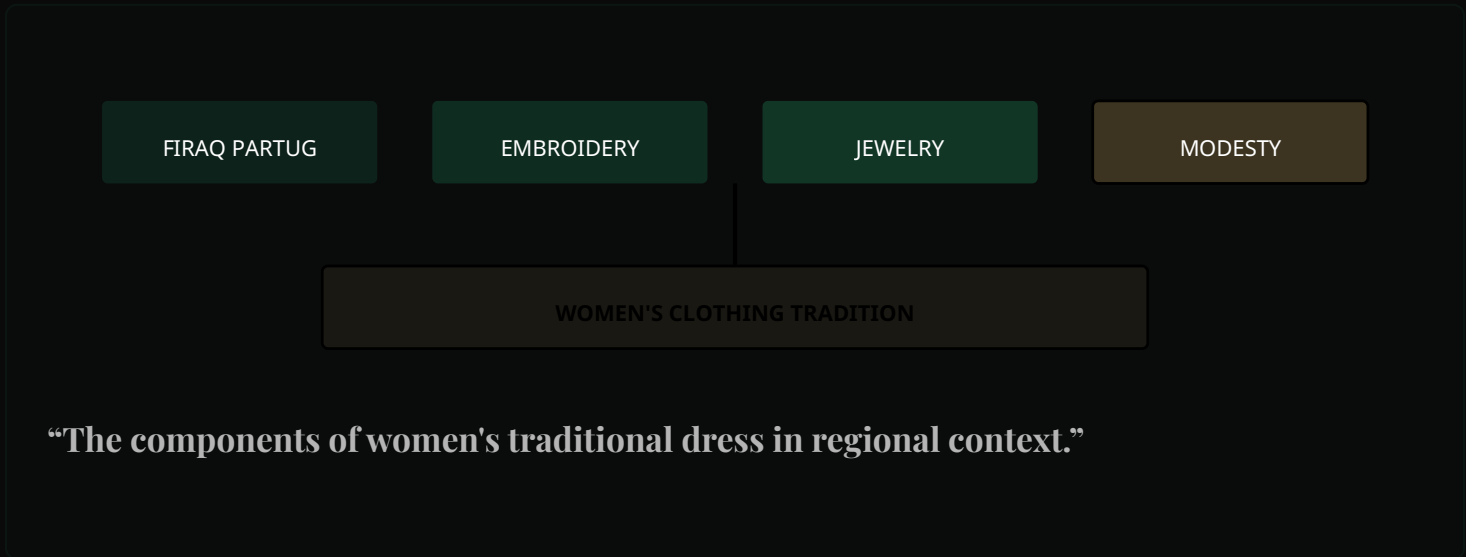
IDENTITY MARKER

“The role of headwear in regional identity communication.”



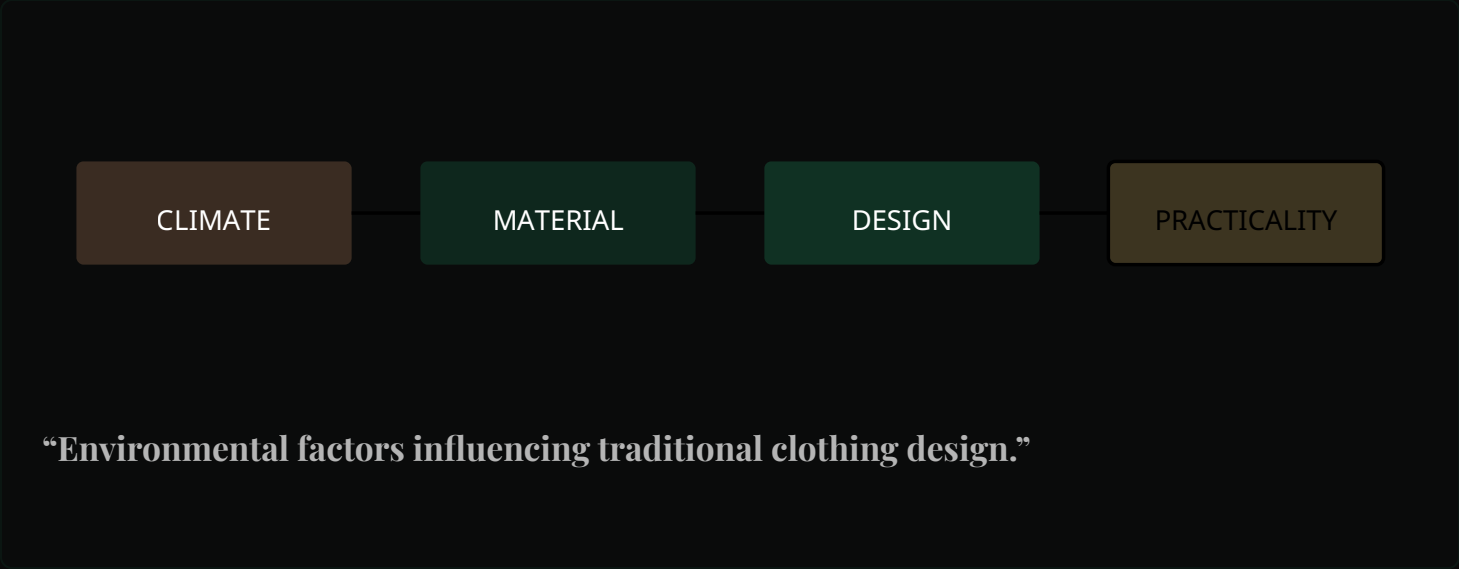
WOMEN'S TRADITIONAL DRESS & CRAFT

Women's clothing in Orakzai is characterized by intricate embroidery and the traditional firaq partug. Recent design research specifically mentions Orakzai dress patterns as part of a cultural revival in the diaspora. Hand-embroidery and waxed cloth designs are documented crafts within the Orakzai Agency, often passed down through families as textile knowledge.¹²



CLOTHING AND ENVIRONMENT

The mountainous climate of Orakzai significantly influences clothing design. Heavy wools and layering are essential for winter, while lighter cottons are preferred for the valleys. Shawls and specific headwear serve both practical needs for warmth and cultural needs for modesty.⁴



GARMENT / PRACTICE	ORAKZAI-SPECIFIC	PASHTUN-WIDE	REGIONAL	HISTORICAL/ CURRENT	EVIDENCE
Shalwar Kameez	Common Use	Core Tradition	Standard	Historical/ Current	Encyclopaedia Iranica [4]
Khet Partug	Documented	Traditional	FATA/KP	Historical	Historical Gazetteer [5]
Pakol	Common Use	Northern Regions	KP/ Orakzai	Historical/ Current	Historical Records [5]
Peshawari Chappal	Common Use	KP Identity	Regional	Current	General Ethnography [4]
Orakzai Embroidery	Direct Evidence	-	Local	Historical/ Current	Gilmour (2013) [2]
Dress Patterns	Direct Evidence	-	Local	Current (Revival)	Ahmad (2025) [1]

MODERN ADAPTATION AND DIGITAL CULTURE

Generational changes, urbanization, and migration have led to the adaptation of traditional clothing. Younger generations often blend traditional garments with modern cuts or western elements. In the diaspora, traditional clothing serves as a powerful symbol of identity during cultural events and weddings. Digital tools and AI are now being explored for the preservation and cataloging of these heritage patterns.³

TRADITION + MODERNITY



“Model of clothing adaptation in contemporary settings.”

HERITAGE PRESERVATION



“Framework for documenting and preserving clothing history.”

AI AND CULTURAL CAUTION

AI should not be used to infer ethnicity from clothing. A garment can express identity, but it cannot prove identity. Not every Pashtun garment is an Orakzai garment, and shared culture does not mean identical culture. Clothing history must be used as cultural evidence with care and proper contextualization.

AUTHOR'S REFLECTION

Clothing was never only fabric. It was something people carried through seasons, gatherings, journeys and generations. A garment could be practical and symbolic at the same time. It could protect against the cold, mark a celebration, express modesty, reflect personal taste or simply feel familiar. For me, preserving clothing heritage is not about deciding that one style is the only authentic way to look Orakzai. It is about remembering the many ways our people have dressed, adapted and expressed themselves. The goal is not to freeze clothing in the past. The goal is to remember it accurately enough that future generations can understand where their styles came from.

“CLOTHING CHANGES. MEMORY REMAINS.”

